

Cyborg Enhancements: Sergius Bulgakov and His Sophiological Perspective

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Abstract

Although Bulgakov did not write about cyborg ethics, his thesis that humankind is the hypostasis of the creaturely Sophia provides a dynamic framework to assess the morality of technological alterations to the human body. As the hypostasis of the creaturely Sophia, the human person has limitless possibilities, including miracle-working. And thus, Jesus Christ's miracles reflect capacities that God intends for all human persons, with the greatest miracle being the resurrection of the body. Bulgakov's thought on miracles offers both a defense of cybernetic modifications and a norm for their limits. This article resources Bulgakov's sophiology to provide an Eastern Christian perspective on cybernetic enhancement technologies. It also engages Bulgakov's sophiology with current scholarship on cybernetic enhancement technologies.

Keywords

sophiology, Eastern Christian, Bulgakov, transhumanism, cyborg, cybernetic enhancements

In the popular video game *Cyberpunk 2077*, the protagonist V navigates a 'post-human' society where humans and machines exist in symbiosis and upgrading cyborg technology is as common as upgrading a cell phone today.¹

Albeit a work of fiction, *Cyberpunk 2077* may offer a glimpse into the future, illuminating the trappings and challenges that cyborg technologies will bring. Today, in fact,

1 'Cyberpunk 2020 Cyberware,' [https://cyberpunk.fandom.com/wiki/Cyberware_\(Cyberpunk_2020\)](https://cyberpunk.fandom.com/wiki/Cyberware_(Cyberpunk_2020)).

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corporations such as Neuralink—which is owned by Elon Musk, a committed transhumanist, and actor in the Cyberpunk 2077 video game—are developing brain augmentation technologies to allow people ‘with paralysis to regain independence.’ This therapeutic function is an ‘initial goal,’ and the ‘long-term vision is to create BMIs (brain-machine interface) that are sufficiently safe and powerful that healthy individuals would want to have them.’² BMIs may revolutionize human communication because they will allow human thought to control computers and cellular devices, and communicate with artificial intelligence.³

BMIs and, more broadly speaking, cyborg technologies are looming ethical issues.⁴ There is no shortage of theological assessments of cyborg technologies.⁵ This paper is unique for two reasons. First, this paper provides an Eastern Christian theological assessment of cyborg technologies. Protestant and Roman Catholics theologians have dominated the discussion of the ethics of cyborg technologies.⁶ Second, this paper is the first study to systematically resource Bulgakov’s sophiology and use Bulgakov’s ideas to

2 ‘Neuralink: Engineering the Brain,’ <https://Neuralink.com/applications/>.

3 Marc Deschamps, ‘Elon Musk Reveals Uncomfortable Cyberpunk 2077 Realization,’ <https://comicbook.com/gaming/news/elon-musk-cyberpunk-2077-uncomfortable-realization/>.

4 For more information, see these very important studies on the topic of enhancement: Jason Eberl, ‘Philosophical anthropology, ethics, and human enhancement,’ in *Contemporary Controversies in Catholic Bioethics*, ed. Jason Eberl (Dordrecht: Springer, 2017); J. Jensen and Jose Widow, ‘Unnatural Enhancements,’ *Irish Theological Quarterly* 83, no. 4 (2018): 347–64, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0021140018795751>. The blurring between human and machine has begun. Within social media platforms cyborgs exist. For instance, in Twitter, cyborgs or bot-assisted humans post ‘tweets’ and make decisions for the human user in the human’s absence. Human users set up an account and then set automated programs to make posts in the user’s absence. See Zi Chu, Steven Gianvecchio, Haining Wang, and Sushil Jajodia, ‘Who is tweeting on Twitter: human, bot, or cyborg?’ in *Proceedings of the 26th Annual Computer Security Applications Conference*, 21–30, 2010, <https://doi.org/10.1145/1920261.1920265>.

5 See, for example, chapter 13 of John Haught’s *Resting on the Future*, the many writings on the topic by Celia Deane-Drummond, the essay by Andrea Vicini on cyborgs (in *Theological Studies*), the edited volume by Ronald Cole-Turner, *Transhumanism and Transcendence: Christian Hope in an Age of Technological Enhancement*.

6 The reader should be aware that Bulgakov was an Orthodox theologian who was highly critical of Catholic theology. In the early 1920s Bulgakov argued that Orthodoxy needed the papacy and it should reunite with the Roman Catholic Church. However, he eventually rejected this idea and by 1925, Bulgakov was critical of Catholic theology and the Pope. One of the many weaknesses of Bulgakov’s minor and major theological trilogy is his uncompromising caricature of Catholicism as papist in polity and overly Aristotelian in its understanding of God. He argues that Catholic theology reflects the God of the philosophers, not the living God whom we encounter in the liturgy, scripture, and life of the Church. (See Sergius Bulgakov, *The Bride of the Lamb*, trans. Boris Jakim (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 2002), 228.) Much of Bulgakov’s theology is written as a corrective to Catholic teaching. Unfortunately, Bulgakov failed to see the diversity in Catholic theology during his life. Moreover, in Bulgakov’s polemic with the Catholic Church, he ignores the Eastern Catholic tradition.

evaluate and defend various cybernetic technologies.⁷ It is a unique addition to Bulgakov's research. Bulgakov's sophiology is not an idiosyncratic theology, but rather an Eastern Christian theology that is a relevant and valuable resource to engage cybernetic technologies with the ancient Christian tradition. Bulgakov provides a relevant theology for Eastern Catholic and Orthodox Christians to assess cybernetic enhancements from an Eastern Christian perspective.

Although Bulgakov did not write about cyborg ethics, his thesis that humankind is the hypostasis of the creaturely Sophia provides a dynamic framework to assess the morality of technological alterations to the human body. As the hypostasis of the creaturely Sophia, the human person has limitless possibilities, including miracle-working. And thus, Jesus Christ's miracles reflect capacities that God intends for all human persons, with the greatest miracle being the resurrection of the body. Bulgakov's thought on miracles offers both a defense of cybernetic modifications and a norm for their limits. Based on Bulgakov's theology of miracles, I will argue that while moderate and radical therapeutic technologies are ethical, popular transhuman cyborg enhancements and cybernetic enhancements that proceed from a selfish intention or purpose are unethical.

My argument will proceed in four steps. First, I will introduce Bulgakov's sophiology and highlight his dynamic interpretation of human nature (i.e., the creaturely Sophia) and how his theology of miracles provides an example of possible human actions and an ethic for evaluating human actions. The second step will explain Bulgakov's theology of the 'greatest miracle,' the general resurrection. Bulgakov's theology of the spiritual body that we will receive at the general resurrection has important implications for evaluating cyborg enhancement technologies. Steps three and four will bring Bulgakov into conversation with contemporary theologians and philosophers evaluating the merits of cybernetic technologies. Step three will examine Bulgakov's criticism of Nikolai Fyodorovich Fedorov to highlight that transhuman cyborg enhancements are false miracles. I will examine two prominent forms of transhuman enhancements including cybernetic immortality and indefinite life extension technologies. Step four will evaluate moderate and radical cyborg technologies but also demonstrate some of the limitations of Bulgakov's thought.

Throughout this paper, I refer to cyborgs and various cyborg/cybernetic enhancement technology. When I refer to cyborgs, I mean beings that consist of organic and inorganic parts. Moreover, there are different types of cyborg/cybernetic enhancement technology that I will discuss and evaluate in this paper. I will employ the threefold distinction that Nicholas Agar and James Delaney make regarding cyborg enhancements: moderate

7 This article builds on the research of T. Dumsday, who is the first scholar to examine the applicability of Bulgakov's critique of Fedorov's thought to the transhuman discussion. Dumsday argues that Bulgakov's critique of technological methods of overcoming death are relevant given recent research on near-death experiences that suggest that human consciousness exists outside the body. My article explains and resources Bulgakov's sophiology to evaluate specific forms of transhumanism and additional cyborg enhancement technologies. See T. Dumsday, 'Sergius Bulgakov's Critique of N. F. Fedorov's Technologized Resurrection (and Why It Still Matters for the Christian Dialogue With Transhumanism),' *Zygon: Journal Of Religion And Science* 55 (2020): 853–74, <https://doi.org/10.1111/zygo.12642>.

cyborg enhancements, radical cyborg enhancements, and transhuman cyborg enhancements. Moderate cyborg enhancements ‘raise the capacity of an individual beyond the standard or healthy range to a level that some other human beings had or currently possess.’ Radical cyborg enhancements ‘raise capacities beyond those ever possessed by any human being, but those who receive them would nevertheless remain human beings.’ Transhumanist cyborg enhancements ‘result in beings that were no longer human, sometimes referred to as “post-human.”’⁸

The Creaturely Sophia and Miracles

Although Bulgakov’s sophiology is controversial and largely ignored in the Orthodox Christian communities today, in North America and Europe, and among non-Orthodox theologians, interest in Bulgakov’s theological system is growing. This is in part due to the proliferation of English translations of Bulgakov’s major and minor trilogies on Sophia written during his tenure as dean at St Sergius Theological Institute in Paris that explicate foundational Orthodox systematic theology. Until recently, his theology was largely unexplored and ignored by scholars.

The controversy as well as attraction to Bulgakov is related to his provocative sophiology that has resulted in his condemnation as a heretic by multiple Russian Orthodox bishops during his lifetime. However, the reception of his theology is complicated by the fact that his sophiology, including his concept of Sophia, is not always clear or consistent. For example, in his early works, such as *Philosophy of Economy* (1906) and *The Unfading Light* (1917), Bulgakov suggests Sophia is a fourth hypostasis in the Trinity. However, in his mature theological work, written during the last two decades of his life (1924–44), Bulgakov rejects this view and identifies Sophia as God’s personalized nature. His short treatise, *Sophia: The Wisdom of God: An Outline of Sophiology* (1937) identifies Sophia as God’s divine nature, and, more specifically, he replaces *ousia* with ‘divine Sophia.’

For Bulgakov, speaking of God’s *ousia* as ‘divine Sophia’ is necessary for a few reasons. First, Bulgakov was a disciple of Vladimir Soloviev—a prominent Russian Orthodox religious philosopher in the late 20th century—and adapted Soloviev’s language and ideas about Sophia to Orthodox theology.⁹ Bulgakov’s theological and philosophical publications are indebted to Soloviev, and they build upon and correct the esoteric, ambiguous, and non-Orthodox elements in Soloviev’s conception of Sophia.¹⁰ By linking the divine Sophia to *ousia*, Bulgakov clarifies an ambiguity in Soloviev, namely what is the divine Sophia. Second, Bulgakov was steeped in the Russian

8 James Delaney, ‘Well-Being and Human Enhancement: A Natural Law Perspective,’ Romanell Center Workshop, Saturday, 11 September 2021. See Nicholas Agar, *Humanity’s End: Why We Should Reject Radical Enhancement* (Cambridge, MA: MIT Press, 2010).

9 Soloviev was Bulgakov’s ‘philosophical guide to Christ.’ Sergius Bulgakov, *Sophia: The Wisdom of God* (New York: Lindisfarne Press, 1993), 10.

10 Bulgakov, *Sophia: The Wisdom of God*, 9. For more information on the relationship between Soloviev and Bulgakov, see the excellent study on the sophiological controversy by Alexis Klimoff. See Alexis Klimoff, ‘On the Sophiological Controversy of the 1930s,’ <https://www.rocorstudies.org/2019/09/03/georges-florovsky-and-the-sophiological-controversy/>.

iconographic tradition and tradition of biblical interpretation that personifies God's Sophia as a quasi-personal entity (see the Novgorod Sophia icon and Prov 1:20–33; 3:13–20; 8:1–36; 9:1–12).¹¹ According to Bulgakov, Sophia was an aspect of the Orthodox liturgical iconography that was unexplored by theology, except for the writings of Vladimir Soloviev and Pavel Florensky. The use of sophiological icons in the divine liturgy is an inspiration for his theology; he tasks himself with explaining the role of Sophia in the life of the Orthodox Church and argues that theological language should reflect the Orthodox religious experience. Bulgakov attempts to reframe the discussion of God's *ousia* within a sophiological context. Third, *ousia* is a depersonalizing term: because the term suggests that God's nature is a philosophical abstraction, failing to articulate God's life and personality. Sophiology provides terminology that more aptly expresses that God is a loving and living trihypostatic being that is encountered in the divine liturgy. Bulgakov's sophiology highlights the relational nature of God.¹² Russian sophiology marries the biblical wisdom tradition, the Russian iconographical tradition, and the Russian religious-philosophical tradition on Sophia to the orthodox teaching on God's *ousia*. The 'divine Sophia' more accurately portrays God as a living divine being who is love and whose nature is alive, replete with God's self-revealing content.

Different from the divine Sophia is Bulgakov's conception of the creaturely Sophia, which is the recipient of God's love and revelation. The creaturely Sophia is the nature of created reality, encompassing visible and invisible creation.

Bulgakov argues that when God created visible and invisible creation out of nothing, God created out of nothing but God's kenotic superabundant love. 'God is love' (1 Jn 4:9) indicates to Bulgakov that God's love is eternal self-sacrificial love. The creation event is a kenotic expression of God's love. Bulgakov writes: 'this trihypostatic kenosis of love is manifest in yet *another* way in the relation of God to the divine world in the act of creation. Here, the Holy Trinity. . . renounces, as it were, in its sacrificially kenotic love the possession of divine world for itself and allows this world to have its own being.'¹³ When God created out of nothing, God pours out God's divine Sophia or God's love and wisdom, simultaneously creating a space or nothingness, non-God, for this love outside God to occupy. As Rowan Williams relates, the divine Sophia 'is not a superficial tidying up of the world's complexity' but rather, God's wisdom holding nothing back in its divine gift of self.¹⁴ The space that God's love and wisdom occupy is the creaturely Sophia, and the space that is not occupied by creation is nothingness or 'non-being.' Non-being is a boundary between the divine and creaturely Sophia and allows for the

11 The Novgorod Sophia icon refers to the icon of Sophia in Saint Sophia Cathedral in Veliky Novgorod, Russia. In this icon, Sophia is depicted as a red-faced, winged angel sitting on a throne between the Theotokos and St John the Baptist and below Jesus Christ.

12 Bulgakov argues that the divine Sophia is 'a special form of *nonhypostatic love in relation to a hypostasis* . . . Sophia loves God without being a hypostasis.' Bulgakov, *The Lamb of God*, 1530.

13 Sergius Bulgakov, *The Bride of the Lamb*. trans. Boris Jakim (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 2002, Kindle e-book), 1838.

14 Rowan Williams, 'Forward' in *Spiritual Diary*, trans. Mark Roosien, Roberto J. De La Noval, Angelica, 2022, xiii.

evolution and growth of the creaturely Sophia. The implication is that the creaturely Sophia is the divine Sophia in kenosis, containing the seeds of the divine Sophia or the images of the proto-images in the divine Sophia. In other words, at the creation event, God places within the creaturely Sophia the program for its development. The final cause of creation is for the creaturely Sophia to evolve into a created image of the divine Sophia. This realization of the creaturely Sophia will occur at the general resurrection when heaven and earth will be transformed into a 'new heaven and a new earth' (Rev 21:1).¹⁵

Until the general resurrection, the creaturely Sophia is the created image of the divine Sophia in process; it has not yet realized what it is meant to be, the perfect image of the divine Sophia. The upshot is that the creaturely Sophia contains the images of the proto-images in the divine Sophia; it contains God's wisdom, which for Bulgakov is also God's power and beauty, in an incipient manner. The proto-images in the divine Sophia are the content of God's wisdom, i.e., all God's knowledge, in its ideal form. The creaturely Sophia contains the shadows or forms of these proto-images. In the creaturely Sophia, these images are in-the-process of realizing the proto-images of the divine Sophia.

However, for Bulgakov, the divine Sophia as God's *ousia* is not an abstraction and therefore should not be never divorced from the divine hypostases. The divine Sophia is always hypostatized and revealed by the persons of the Trinity. This relationship of the divine Sophia to the divine hypostases extends to the created hypostases, the human hypostases, relationship to the creaturely Sophia. Just as the hypostases of the Holy Trinity *hypostatize* or are conscious of and exist in their divine Sophia, the created human persons hypostatize the creaturely Sophia. The creaturely Sophia is human nature, and it is through the human hypostases that creaturely Sophia accomplishes its final cause, to be an image of the divine Sophia in created reality.¹⁶

Bulgakov writes, that the human hypostasis is the 'hypostasis of creaturely Sophia'¹⁷ and 'a potential god-man' that 'had in the depths of his spirit the possibility of participating in the divine life, of living by the divine nature, and of drawing from this nature the powers necessary to sophianize the world, to disclose the creaturely Sophia in the world.'¹⁸ For Bulgakov, the human person as 'hypostasis of creaturely Sophia' introduces not only 'the possibility of participating in the divine life,' but also 'drawing from

15 Bulgakov, *The Lamb of God*, 2205.

16 Bulgakov explicates that human beings are images of the Trinity in *The Friend of the Bridegroom* [1927] and *The Orthodox Church* [1935]. See Sergius Bulgakov, *The Friend of the Bridegroom: On the Orthodox Veneration of the Forerunner*, trans. Boris Jakim (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 2003), 144, 155; Sergius Bulgakov, *The Orthodox Church*, trans. Lydia Kesich (Yonkers, NY: St Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1988), 104–5. More recently, Brandon Morgan asserts a similar claim. See Brandon L. Morgan, 'Reimaging Aesthetics: Sergius Bulgakov on Seeing the Wisdom of Creation,' *Irish Theological Quarterly* 83, no.2 (2018): 149–63, 159, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0021140018757885>.

17 See Bulgakov, *The Lamb of God*, 2948. The proper creaturely hypostasis of the creaturely Sophia is the Theotokos. Mary, the mother of Jesus, is a created human hypostasis that perfectly hypostatizes the creaturely Sophia. See Walter Nunzio Sisto, *The Soul of the World: The Mother of God in the Theology of Sergius Bulgakov* (Abingdon: Routledge, 2018).

18 Bulgakov, *The Bride of the Lamb*, 2113.

this nature the powers necessary to sophianize the world' and thus 'disclose creaturely Sophia in the world.' Bulgakov believes that this 'living by the divine nature' is the ideal relationship of the human hypostasis to the creaturely Sophia. Human beings are meant to participate by grace in God's life, to be deified, and to deify or 'sophianize' creation, and the human hypostases have the potential to hypostatize the creaturely Sophia in a manner analogous to how the divine hypostases hypostatize the divine Sophia. To 'sophianize' creation is another way of expressing that God gives to humankind a role in the eschaton when 'God may be all in all' (1 Cor 15:28).

The implication of the human hypostasis's relationship to the creaturely Sophia and the eschaton is that human beings are dynamic and evolving creatures that God created to prepare creation for the eschaton.¹⁹ Unfortunately, humankind failed to accomplish its potential, and 'instead of leading [creation] to God . . . man degraded himself by approaching this world; he thus diminished his spiritual force and his power over the world.'²⁰ Not all is lost because Jesus Christ actualizes the 'potential god-man' abilities possible for prelapsarian humankind.²¹ Jesus' ministry and life between his incarnation and ascension are important for appreciating the human hypostasis's unique relationship to the creaturely Sophia, because, according to Bulgakov, during this time Jesus' divinity or powers of his divine Sophia are kenotically diminished so that Jesus experiences and redeems humankind as a human hypostasis without relying upon his divine powers. Jesus' miracles and powers over demons and creation are abilities that are made possible by his created nature, the creaturely Sophia. God the Father, guides Jesus, but his accomplishments during the time between his incarnation and ascension were 'human accomplishments' or to use sophiological language, relied upon his hypostatization of the creaturely Sophia. Jesus recapitulates the role of humankind to the creaturely Sophia and provides an example of 'potential god-man' abilities possible for prelapsarian humankind because Jesus Christ perfectly exists as a human hypostasis and hypostatizes the creaturely Sophia.²²

In his 1932 article, 'Christ's Miracles in the Gospels,' Bulgakov explicates this idea. He argues that Jesus' miracles (e.g., walking on water, multiplication of loaves of bread and fish, healing the sick, raising the dead) are not divine acts *upon* the world, but rather 'the action of God *within* the limits of the world, directing the life of [the world].'²³

19 Bulgakov's discussion of the consequences of the original sin is the broader context of this quotation. Adam had the ability to sophianize the world, to become a 'god-man,' but Adam failed. Later in *The Bride of the Lamb*, Bulgakov explains that Christ recapitulates this relationship between Adam and the creaturely Sophia. Because of Christ's accomplishments, human beings gain this ability back, to sophianize the world.

20 Bulgakov, *The Bride of the Lamb*, 2126.

21 Jesus Christ recapitulates the potential god-manhood of Adam. Bulgakov writes that Adam was a potential god-man that 'had in the depths of his spirit the possibility of participating in the divine life, of living by the divine nature, and of drawing from this nature the powers necessary to sophianize the world, to disclose the creaturely Sophia in the world.' Bulgakov, *The Lamb of God*, 2113.

22 Jesus' resurrection is the archetype for the general resurrection. Jesus is the first human being to experience the grace of the resurrection.

23 Sergius Bulgakov, *Relics and Miracles: Two Theological Essays*, trans. Boris Jakim (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 2011. Kindle e-book), 794–95.

Bulgakov's point is that when Jesus raises Lazarus from the dead, for example, he is actualizing human power and the possibility for human hypostases. Jesus Christ is the god-man by virtue of the hypostatic union; however, he actualizes the 'potential god-man' that is possible for every human hypostasis. Here, as Robert Slesinski notes, Bulgakov is committed to St Athanasius's 'primordial theological intuition: God became man so that man can become God.'²⁴ Jesus Christ accomplishes the restoration of humankind *within* the confines and limitations of the creaturely Sophia.²⁵ His miracles do not introduce any new content to the creaturely Sophia, but rather Jesus' miracles actualize a possibility of the creaturely Sophia in the concrete. The result is that his divine Sophia and the powers associated with his divine nature are not the direct cause of his miraculous powers. Rather these miraculous actions realize the powers contained within the creaturely Sophia; they are the initial gifts bestowed by God on creation. When Christ heals, he heals as a human, actualizing human capacities, or more specifically he realizes the hidden divine capacity or proto-image in the creaturely Sophia. Bulgakov writes that Jesus' miracles

represented humanity's testimony about itself, for man is called to be the 'lord' of the world; he is the king of creation, the creaturely god. And this power of man over the world is attested in the perfect Man with staggering force, although (it is necessary to add at once) miracle-working is not something that belongs to Him alone but is, in general, proper to many spirit-bearing men of the Old and New Testaments. From the fact that the miracles are worked by Christ with the participation of His humanity, it follows that all of them have a human character, i.e., are accessible to man and are possible for him.²⁶

The miracles recorded in the Bible are not supernatural or unnatural phenomena, but rather natural capacities possible for Christian believers. Using his sophiological language, miracles actualize ideas within the creaturely Sophia. The miraculous power of a miracle is caused by the manifestation of a divine idea in concrete form.²⁷ A miracle is not an 'extraordinary event manifesting divine intervention in human affairs'²⁸ but rather natural human abilities for human beings attempting to accomplish the will of God.

24 Robert F. Slesinski, *The Theology of Sergius Bulgakov* (Yonkers, NY: St Vladimir's Press, 2017), 157.

25 The ascension is the culmination of Jesus' life, ministry, and redemption of humankind. When Jesus returns to heaven his kenosis of his divinity, his divine Sophia, ends. Before the ascension, his miraculous actions are human actions.

26 Bulgakov, *Relics and Miracles*, 818–21.

27 Bulgakov relates the miraculous power of humankind to the phenomenon of prophecy. Here we have an example of how hypostatization functions. A prophet becomes aware of a divine image (foreknowledge) within the creaturely Sophia. Nevertheless, not all prophecy is of equal value. The intensity of the prevision is dependent upon spiritual preparation of the person receiving the vision as well as the involvement of the Holy Spirit. Sergius Bulgakov, *The Lamb of God*, 4904.

28 Merriam-Webster Dictionary, 'Miracle,' <https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/miracle>.

Miracles are any acts that achieve the divine purpose, no matter how unspectacular they may seem from a worldly standpoint.²⁹

Thus, for Bulgakov, miracles should not be limited to events that seemingly defy the laws of physics and natural explanation. Since the creaturely Sophia includes spiritual, non-material reality and material reality, miracle-working, which is a power of the creaturely Sophia, may have either a non-material or material causality. There are multiple avenues through which miracle-working is possible. For instance, a sick child that is healed from cancer by prayer and a sick child that is healed from cancer by chemotherapy are both recipients of miracles. In Bulgakov's ontological scheme, both miracle workers are 'acting upon the forces of nature' and realizing a capacity of the human being (e.g., the science of prayer and the science of medicine) made in the 'image of the trihypostatic God.'³⁰ Then miracles are actualizations of the 'the creative principle' that reside in every human being because human beings are the hypostases of the creaturely Sophia.³¹ The creaturely Sophia is not simply a static nature but a living, dynamic nature that provides human beings with the context and ability for creative human action. Creative actions that seek to conform to God's will (i.e., to heal a person) realize an image in the creaturely Sophia. Since the creaturely Sophia contains the incipient mirrored proto-images in divine Sophia, there are numerous possible actualizations of these images.

The actualizations of these proto-images may not necessarily benefit humankind, and, therefore, Bulgakov distinguishes between true and false miracles. He writes that while 'true miracles are manifestations of the spiritual mastery of the world through spiritual causality according to God's will, and lead, in the final analysis, to the deification of the world through the communion of the latter with the God-Man by the power of Christ.' False miracles 'signify the appearance of human power in the world without the mastery of it with God's help.'³² Notice that for Bulgakov, the issue is the intention and purpose behind the miracle or 'human power' and whether that miracle is open to God's assistance. Bulgakov's thought implies that scientific investigation 'accomplishes true miracles' when the underlying intention and purpose is love and mercy. By contrast scientific investigation creates false miracles when it serves 'human egotism, pride, and evil passions.'³³ Bulgakov's sophiology of miracles provides a theological system that is inclusive of science and will aid our discussion on the evaluation of cyborg enhancement technology.

29 This is not a trite statement. We need only to examine human experiences of grief to have an idea of what Bulgakov means. It is the 'small things' (e.g., phone calls, providing a meal for the bereaved, a short visit) that can be miraculous to the grieving person. These actions help the grieving person process and come to terms with their loss.

30 Bulgakov, *Relics and Miracles*, 732–33.

31 Bulgakov, *Relics and Miracles*, 733.

32 Bulgakov, *Relics and Miracles*, 717–19.

33 Bulgakov, *Relics and Miracles*, 722.

The Spiritual Body and The General Resurrection

Not only does Jesus recapitulate the role of humankind as a 'potential god-man' to the creaturely Sophia, but he is also the first human hypostasis to be transformed through what is the final and greatest miracle, the resurrection of his body.³⁴ Bulgakov stresses that the resurrection is not properly a human miracle but rather 'the work of the entire Holy Trinity.'³⁵ The miracles we create and experience in life are a foretaste of the resurrection because miracles actualize the potential capacity of the creaturely Sophia. When the human body is resurrected, the human hypostasis becomes a 'god-man' and fully realizes the role God has given humankind as the hypostasis of the creaturely Sophia. In the general resurrection, God enhances and transforms the creaturely Sophia, and thus the human body.

Bulgakov's sophiological interpretation of the general resurrection implies that the human body is made for such enhancement. His theology of the resurrected body is an exposition of St Paul's writing that at the general resurrection the human 'natural body' will become a 'spiritual body.' St Paul writes: 'So will it be with the resurrection of the dead. The body that is sown is perishable, it is raised imperishable; it is sown in dishonor, it is raised in glory; it is sown in weakness, it is raised in power; it is sown a natural body, it is raised a spiritual body' (1 Cor 15:37–44). The 'spiritual body' will be imperishable, glorified, raised in power. It is not clear from Scripture or Tradition what this resurrected spiritual body will look like or how it will function, but what is clear is that the body is *enhanced* beyond its current natural and perishable state. The spiritual, resurrected body is not a new body *per se* but a body that is fully enhanced, or to use Bulgakov's idea, it is fully energized to meet the demands of the human spirit. I recognize that my application of the term 'enhanced' to the resurrection of the body is controversial. I concede that the grace of the resurrection is ineffable. Yet, my use of the term is not inappropriate within a Bulgakovian framework because for Bulgakov the grace of resurrection builds upon the sophiological foundation of the human body. For Bulgakov, the resurrection of the body means that the body will finally meet the 'demands of the spirit,' or that the body and spirit will work in unison. The resurrection is the final and complete enhancement of the human body. Cybernetic enhancements may be a foretaste of the enhancement of the body at the general resurrection since cybernetic enhancements improve bodily function to better comport to the eternal human spirit. However, the relationship between cyborg enhancements and the resurrection of the body to the human body is analogical, not equivocal. Moreover, the resurrected body will have the ability to accomplish what is possible for the deified human spirit (e.g., non-spatial limitation and communication with God directly). The resurrected body will be completely transfigured and imbued with the hypostatic human spirit that is deified by God's grace.

34 Bulgakov argues that human hypostases are images of Jesus' divine-human hypostasis. Jesus does not have a created human hypostasis. Bulgakov stresses that Jesus is fully human and that human hypostases are made after the image of Jesus's divine-human hypostases. The only difference between Jesus' hypostasis and other human hypostases between the incarnation and his ascension is that Jesus does not experience the effects of the original sin.

35 Bulgakov, *Relics and Miracles*, 1386.

Nevertheless, when the general resurrection occurs most deceased humans will lack a natural body due to the decomposition or destruction of their corpses; yet, the Orthodox Christian tradition teaches that resurrection is for all people. What then is resurrected if there is no corpse?

Recall that the resurrection is 'the completion of creation' where the creaturely Sophia through/with the human hypostases attains its final and full revelation as the image of the divine Sophia. This means that the proto-images within the divine Sophia that are the basis of images within the creaturely Sophia are attained and manifested in the creaturely Sophia. At the general resurrection, the human person realizes its proto-image in the divine Sophia, the eternal human image of what God has planned for the human person to become, a spiritual body.³⁶ The bodily image of us contained in the creaturely Sophia is revealed in the concrete as its eternal proto-image. Bulgakov writes that the human body has 'a dynamic center, as a certain bodily entelechy, is preserved in every man, even in the case of its total decomposition.'³⁷ Bodily decomposition that breaks down the body into elements that in turn become fertilizer for plants will not frustrate the resurrection because the 'bodily entelechy' of the decomposed human body remains in the creaturely Sophia. This 'bodily entelechy' in the creaturely Sophia is what will be resurrected if the natural body is not present.

There are a few implications from this discussion relevant to my analysis of cyborg enhancement technologies. First, the resurrection of the body is the final and greatest miracle for human beings. The resurrection is a miraculous enhancement that transforms the natural, physical body into a corporeal-spiritual body. Second, the spiritual body we will receive at the general resurrection is our true body because God made human beings for resurrection, to become a spiritual body that is deified by God's grace. To frame the general resurrection within this cyborg discussion, the spiritual body is a radical spiritual enhancement that transforms the body into a new 'state.' The new state of the body will not be 'constrained by our laws of spatiality.'³⁸ Third, technological alterations to the human body [in the present age] will not frustrate God's plan to enhance the natural body into a spiritual body. Since the natural body has a dynamic center that is persevered and resurrected despite total decomposition, mechanical enhancements to the body will not frustrate the general resurrection because they do not affect the dynamic center of the body.

Fedorov and Death

Before considering the possibility of such mechanical enhancements, we can first note a limit to them that Bulgakov was to develop through his critical analysis of the work of Nikolai Fyodorovich Fedorov (d. 1903). Fedorov, who was a well-known Russian thinker that advocated for cosmism,³⁹ was regarded as a forerunner of transhumanism

36 Bulgakov, *The Bride of the Lamb*, 450.

37 Bulgakov, *Relics and Miracles: Two Theological Essays*, 436–40.

38 Bulgakov, *Relics and Miracles: Two Theological Essays*, 1439.

39 Cosmism was a philosophical movement at the end of the 19th century that blended Orthodox theology with science.

and argued that humans have an obligation to cure the human race's greatest foe, death, utilizing science and technology.⁴⁰ Fedorov was one of the first thinkers to advocate for 'technical immortality.'⁴¹ Fedorov, who was also a devout Russian Orthodox believer, interpreted the general resurrection as a call for human beings to use technology to bring people back from the dead. In his words, the 'eschaton will involve the return of the dead to life, by God's plan as revealed in scripture, but God will accomplish this through human technology rather than miracles.'⁴² Science and technology are the means for human beings 'to exercise control over [the world].'⁴³ Fedorov believed that God would inspire humankind to create technologies to make the general resurrection a reality.

Bulgakov's most sustained theological analysis of Fedorov's thought appears in his *The Unfading Light* (1917).⁴⁴ There he concludes that Fedorov's project fails because he advances a humanism that does not leave any room for 'divine force.' He collapses the 'divine-human synthesis' and Jesus Christ becomes nothing more than a philosopher that provides an example for us to emulate. Fedorov advocates a violent technological resuscitation and not a true resurrection. For Bulgakov, resurrection entails a synergy between God and humankind, 'a divine-human act requiring the joining of divine grace and human action.' Humanity must acknowledge 'fully the divine side of resurrecting'; they participate in it through 'their aspirations of resurrecting.'⁴⁵

Thus, for Bulgakov, Fedorov's technological resuscitation is an example of what we saw above: a 'false miracle' or a miracle that ultimately serves the human ego as it seeks to overcome death without God, thereby distorting the Christian view of resurrection.

Nevertheless, Bulgakov believed that there is much to learn from Fedorov's embrace of technology, even if not in the 'crude form' it took in his work.⁴⁶ Bulgakov believed that Fedorov was right in his view that humankind has a central role in the world and God's plan for resurrection. And thus, he does not reject Fedorov's insistence on the use of technology. Rather he believes that Fedorov overestimates human abilities and technology and underestimates God's work in human life, and, as Oravec writes, Fedorov's project is insufficiently eschatological, leaving no conclusive role for Christ in the resurrection.⁴⁷

What Fedorov fails to understand is the basic premise of sophiology: God is a relational divine being that has created humankind for a relationship with God, and this

40 See also *Russian Cosmism*, ed. Boris Groys (New York: MIT Press, 2018).

41 Aidan Nichols, *Wisdom from Above: A Primer in the Theology of Father Sergius Bulgakov* (Leominster: Gracewing, 2005), 220.

42 Dumsday, 855.

43 Slesinski, 155.

44 Sergius Bulgakov, *The Unfading Light: Contemplations and Speculations*, trans. Allan T. Smith (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 2012), 375.

45 Bulgakov, *The Unfading Light*, 376.

46 Bulgakov, *The Unfading Light*, 381.

47 Johannes Miroslav Oravec, *God As Love: The Concept and Spiritual Aspects of Agape in Modern Russian Thought* (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 2014), 188.

relationship is fulfilled in the general resurrection. Humankind is resurrected by God, who not only initiates but fulfills this relationship with humankind. This does not deny humankind's role in preparing for the general resurrection and second coming of Jesus. In this preparation, technology as a form of human creativity or miracle-working is appropriate. But the crucial takeaway from Bulgakov's theology is that the general resurrection and overcoming of mortality and death are initiated by God alone. According to Bulgakov, 'death is not something episodic in life, something that can be overcome (like a sickness)' but rather it is a 'fundamental quality of life.'⁴⁸ Death is a fundamental quality of life that establishes a 'metaphysical boundary of life' that only God may overcome. In Bulgakov's theological narrative, death is a consequence of sin, the loss of immortality, and, more precisely, it destroys the connection between the spirit and the body composite. Technologies that attempt to overcome or defeat death will fail because the spirit cannot be contained or reconnected to a body through a material mechanism.

Evaluation of Cyborg Enhancements

Cybernetic Immortality

Bulgakov's criticisms of Fedorov provide insights for applying his thought to cyborg enhancement technologies. First and foremost, transhumanist enhancement technologies are problematic if they attempt to transfer consciousness to a virtual body because doing so breaks the connection between the spirit and body.

Although mainstream transhumanists are not advocating the reanimation of corpses envisioned by Fedorov, the notion of 'cybernetic immortality' is popular.⁴⁹ Raymond Kurzweil,⁵⁰ a prominent transhumanist and the director of engineering at Google, argues that based on his research on the exponential growth of information technology, by the 2040s 'immortal software-based humans' will be possible.⁵¹ Technology after two decades will allow our consciousness to move seamlessly into virtual bodies as well as new bodies created from nanotechnologies.⁵² This technology will make immortality possible insofar as our consciousness is indefinitely transferred to new virtual and mechanical bodies.⁵³ Whether this technology will be a reality in two decades remains to be seen;

48 Bulgakov, *Relics and Miracles*, 1369.

49 Nelson R. Kellog, 'Cybernetic Immortality and its Discontents,' *Theology and Science* 13, no. 2 (2015): 162–74, <https://doi.org/10.1080/14746700.2015.1023526>.

50 Although Kurzweil is one of the most popular transhumanists, he is an outlier in the scientific community. See John Rennie, 'The Immortal Ambitions of Ray Kurzweil: A Review of *Transcendent Man*,' <https://www.scientificamerican.com/article/the-immortal-ambitions-of-ray-kurzweil/>.

51 Ray Kurzweil, 'The Law of Accelerating Returns,' in *Alan Turing: Life and Legacy of a Great Thinker* (Berlin: Springer, 2004), 381.

52 Ray Kurzweil, 'Immortality by 2045,' <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=f28LPwR8BdY>.

53 Ray Kurzweil, *The Singularity is Near: When Humans Transcend Biology* (New York: Penguin, 2005), 374.

however, based on Bulgakov's response to Fedorov, this form of transhumanism is problematic because it fails to articulate an anthropology commensurate with Christian theology. Michael Burdett succinctly summarizes the main problem with transhumanism: transhumanism 'depends upon an ontology of information.'⁵⁴ Human consciousness is reduced to a neural network and the medium of that network (i.e., the human body) is irrelevant. This reductionism—exemplified in Kurzweil's proposal for immortal software-based humans—fails to consider the spiritual dimension of the human being. For this reason, Brandon Gallaher, an Orthodox theologian and Bulgakov scholar, writes that 'transhumanism is Satanic' because it is a 'Luciferin religion of "Mangodhood" . . . which is characterized by self-worship or self-deification of humanity.'⁵⁵ For my purpose, Burdett and Gallaher illustrate that the transhumanism professed by Kurzweil is entirely inconsistent with the Christian sophiological tradition because it assumes that human ingenuity and technology will overcome mortality and achieve a post-human state, attaining a kind-of *Übermensch*.⁵⁶

Employing Bulgakov's terminology, Bulgakov might add to this discussion that Kurzweil's proposal is a bad use of science or a 'false miracle' because he overemphasizes the human will and assumes that the human body is something dispensable. What makes this a false miracle is his overly humanistic approach to achieving immortality that disfigures a divine idea present in the creaturely Sophia. This criticism, although expressed in a Bulgakovian manner, is common among Christian theologians engaging with transhumanism. For example, Celia Deane-Drummond, a prominent Catholic theologian and writer on transhumanism, provides an important insight that this particular kind of transhuman philosophy is problematic because 'by attempting to control particular contingent problems of the human condition, it inadvertently commits an error ancient in its roots: attempting to find succor by distancing the human from its material, creaturely, animal origins.'⁵⁷ This form of transhumanism reveals a pseudo-Manicheism that not only devalues the body, but the natural world, the environment and the human race because it 'promotes a disconnection within the self (between mind and body) . . . but

54 Michael Burdett, *Technology and the Rise of Transhumanism: Beyond Genetic Engineering* (Cambridge: Grove, 2014), 17.

55 Brandon Gallaher, 'Godmanhood vs Mangodhood: An Eastern Orthodox Response to Transhumanism,' *Studies in Christian Ethics* 32, no. 2 (2019): 200–215, 201–2, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0953946819827136>.

56 Friedrich Nietzsche, *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* in *The Portable Nietzsche*, ed. and trans. Walter Kaufmann (New York: Penguin, 1976), 124. As Gallaher correctly states, Nietzsche is an inspiration for both More and Kurzweil. Brandon Gallaher, 'Godmanhood vs Mangodhood: An Eastern Orthodox Response to Transhumanism' *Studies in Christian Ethics* 32, no. 2 (2019), 200–215, 203–4, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0953946819827136>.

57 Celia Deane-Drummond, 'Taking Leave of the Animal? The Theological and Ethical Implications of Transhuman Projects' in *Transhumanism and Transcendence: Christian Hope in an Age of Technological Enhancement*, 115–30, Washington, DC: Georgetown University Press, 2011, 125.

also because it promotes disconnection between selves.⁵⁸ By ‘disconnection between selves’ Deane-Drummond means the sociological dimensions of humanity and the importance of human relationships for human growth and happiness. This is a profound insight that Kurzweil’s philosophy neglects. Michael Spezio notes that Kurzweil defines what it means to be human as simply ‘our ability to reach beyond our limitations.’⁵⁹ This definition implies a truncated anthropology that is not consistent with orthodox Christian theology that teaches human beings are not simply individuals but also one human race with one human nature.

Bulgakov’s sophiology has much to add to this criticism. The human hypostasis shares sophianic nature, the creaturely Sophia, with all living creatures, including and most importantly other human hypostases. Uploading the human mind to a cloud is a gross misuse of human technology because it benefits only the recipient of the technology. It may solve the problem of mortality, but it creates many more problems such as a complete failure to consider the social/sophiological dimension of humanity. Human beings live and exist in communion with other human hypostases that share one human nature.⁶⁰ Salvation from death is a collective experience.⁶¹ Any attempt to defeat death by technology will fail.

I am reminded of the Hindu myth of Sadhguru, whom Krishna curses with immortality, forever living with the guilt of his actions and outliving all the people he loves. The lesson of the myth is that immortality is a curse when it only benefits the individual. Living forever may seem desirable until we consider that it will mean outliving all the mortals we love. Bulgakov, who is always concerned about the salvation of humanity, not simply the individual, argues for a form of *apokatastasis* because he recognizes the sociological dimension of the human being.⁶² Salvation is in some sense incomplete without the people we love. This is the problem with individualism and why Bulgakov rejects individualism as a repulsive, diabolical ideology because it fails to appreciate the sophianic basis of humanity, that the human hypostasis is a member of the human race. Individualism is a heresy because while it is attuned to the importance of the individual human experience it ignores the underlying premise about the interconnectedness, even

58 Celia Deane-Drummond, ‘Taking Leave of the Animal,’ 123.

59 Michael Spezio, ‘Human or Vulcan? Theological Considerations of Emotional Control Enhancement’ in *Transhumanism and Transcendence: Christian Hope in an Age of Technological Enhancement*, 115–30, Washington, DC: Georgetown University Press, 2011, 145.

60 For Bulgakov, the trinitarian relationships of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit offer an analogy of the ideal relationship of human beings to other humans. To be made in the image of God, is to be made in the image of the Blessed Trinity. Resurrected human beings will in some way reveal the trinitarian relations of the trinitarian persons to one another, to other human beings.

61 Following the Orthodox tradition, Bulgakov writes in his *Bride of the Lamb* that everyone receives resurrection, but not everyone receives salvation.

62 See Bulgakov, *The Bride of the Lamb*, 520.

in death, between human beings.⁶³ Bulgakov, in his earliest sophiological work, *Philosophy of Economy: The World as Household* (1912), provides a sustained criticism of individualism. He argues that individualism disfigures the true purpose and creative dimension of humankind that entails vouchsafing the human dignity of the individual and the collective human race.⁶⁴ Individualism disfigures human creativity that should express God's loving wisdom for the human race and not simply an individual.

Bulgakov's sophiology helps to highlight that Kurzweil's transhumanism philosophy is unethical for Christians because it disconnects the mind from the body and the human being from humanity. Moreover, as Ronald Cole-Turner, illustrated in his critique of transhumanism, Kurzweil's transhumanism fails to capture the Christian ethos that stresses the importance of self-emptying love for other human beings as opposed to the 'self-aggrandizing, self-expanding tendency that drives transhumanism.'⁶⁵ If we take

63 Kurzweil and other transhumanists such as Nick Bostrom will likely not be swayed by Bulgakov's observation because they do not represent the Christian tradition; however, there is a growing body of evidence from the thanatologists and evolutionary anthropologists on the importance of the societal dimension of the human being for survival and to achieve happiness and self-fulfillment. (See Nick Bostrom, 'Future of Humanity' in *New Waves in Philosophy of Technology*, 186–216, eds Jan-Kyry Berg Olsen, Evan Selinger, & Soren Ris (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2009), <https://nickbostrom.com/papers/future/>.) For example, the field of death studies has revealed the importance of the social dimension (e.g., relationships with family, friends, and human society/culture) of dying people across cultures. Charles Corr's *task-based approach* to dying is a popular standard within the field of death studies. His research reveals that the social dimension is among one of the four basic dimensions of what it means to be human. Satisfying or enhancing this dimension along with the physical, social, and spiritual is a data driven approach to helping the dying find meaning and comfort. (See Charles Corr and Donna Corr, *Death & Dying, Life & Living*, 7th edition, Belmont, CA: Cengage Learning, 2009.) Moreover, evolutionary anthropologist, Brian Hare and Vanessa Wood in their recent book *Survival of the Friendliest* argue that the friendliest of the human beings towards other humans, (e.g., care for the social dimension) allowed for the survival and success of humanity. (See Brian Hare and Vanessa Woods, *Survival of the Friendliest: Understanding Our Origins and Rediscovering Our Common Humanity*, New York: Random, 2020.) The trait friendliness leads to cooperation in-mass that conferred wide-ranging advantages which further facilitated the evolution of humans to be friendly and socially oriented organisms. For my research, this study provides evidence that human beings are genetically predisposed towards relationships towards other human beings. In this context, Kurzweil's proposal may not be a step forward for the human species but rather a step backwards because this technology benefits individuals, not the human species and ignores the most important trait that led to our species survival, friendliness.

64 Bulgakov rejects the notion of economics as a study of the mechanics of financial transactions. This is rooted in a materialism and shows its ugly head in a radical consumerism. In *The Philosophy of Economy*, Bulgakov attempts to restore humankind's place in the world as given in Christian revelation. Economics describes how we approach and interact with the world, and it must include a philosophy of life. Creation is economic and oriented toward life. All creation is interrelated by a life force. This inner life force of creation is Sophia.

65 Ronald Cole-Turner, 'Transhumanism and Christianity' in *Transhumanism and Transcendence: Christian Hope in the Age of Technological Enhancement*, 191–203, Washington, DC: Georgetown University Press, 2011, 199.

seriously Bulgakov's premise that human nature is the creaturely Sophia or God's divine nature kenotically depleted of God's power and glory, then human beings are not simply made in the image and likeness of a God who is love, but the kenotic love of God is the basis of human nature. If a technology is to enhance the human race or create a post-human race, for it to be acceptable for a Christian, it must in some way be an act of self-giving love or it is an egotistical action. Transhumanism, at least as it is interpreted by Kurzweil and Nick Bostrom⁶⁶ in a sophiological worldview, is unacceptable because it is an inherently individualistic project. It proceeds from a selfish purpose and intention that does not comport with Jesus' greatest commandment, which is the basis of all Christian ethics, to love 'God with all thy heart, and with all thy soul, and with all thy mind . . . love thy neighbor as thyself' (Matt 22:37–40).

The problematic individualism latent in transhumanism highlighted by Bulgakov's sophiological perspective is evident when due consideration is taken to consider who are the beneficiaries of technological immortality. If transhumanists succeed in creating post-humans, this will be a post-humanism of the rich. This premise is not outlandish. Justin Anderson, Joseph R. Laracy, and Thomas Marlowe's recent research demonstrate the inequitable distribution of technology to the poor and vulnerable is an injustice that is further widening the socio-economic gap between the wealthy and the poor.⁶⁷ Unfortunately, we need to look no further that the disparity in healthcare services between the wealthy and the poor in developed countries today for evidence that this disparity in access to technology will likely continue with transhuman enhancements. The result may be that immortality is preferential treatment for those who have the income to afford it, the wealthy. Technologies that privilege a select few and may result in a post-human super race is 'inhuman' or 'un-sophianic' because the sophianic basis of human nature predisposes human beings to kenotic love; which may be expressed as a love of neighbor and prioritizing the needs of others before our own needs. The fault of Kurzweil's transhumanism is that it is not concerned with human dignity or the human race, but rather the privilege of wealthy individuals.

Bulgakov's criticism of Fedorov sheds light on another problem with Kurzweil's transhumanism for Christians. Like Fedorov, Kurzweil fails to acknowledge the need for the synergy between human activity and God's grace or activity. God provides human beings with a dynamic and limitless nature that is the basis for miracles. However, miracle-working is premised on the inherent value of human creatureliness and limitation and the willingness of the human being to work with God. God bestows on humankind this creative power to make miracles but when this creative power is used to serve obtuse intentions such as 'escaping death' it will ultimately fail. Attempting to transfer consciousness to software will result in a catastrophe. Death cannot be overcome without God's help. If immortal software-based technology develops, the post-human that is created is at best a

66 See Nick Bostrom, 'Future of Humanity' in *New Waves in Philosophy of Technology*, 186–216, eds Jan-Kyre Berg Olsen, Evan Selinger, & Soren Ris (New York: Palgrave MacMillan, 2009), <https://nickbostrom.com/papers/future>.

67 See Justin Anderson, Joseph R. Laracy, Thomas Marlowe, 'A Multi-Disciplinary Analysis of Catholic Social Teaching with Implications for Engineering and Technology,' *Journal of Systemics, Cybernetics, and Informatics* 18, no. 6 (2020): 41–49, 49. ISSN: 16904524.

zombie-like copy of the original person because the human spirit is not present. When a death occurs, the spirit leaves the body behind. This new post-human may look like and contain the memories or data of the human it copied, but it is a copy of the brain functions of a human person, not the person. The result is that immortal software-based humans that achieve cybernetic immortality undermine the dignity, complexity, and uniqueness of the human person because it diminishes the infinite creative human spirit to a physiological mechanism that can be duplicated.

Indefinite Life Extension Technologies

While Kurzweil's proposal is unethical, what are the implications of Bulgakov's sophiology for transhumanists, such as Aubrey de Gray, who advocate for transhuman technologies that will allow for indefinite life extension without causing death or dispensing with the human body? Gray argues that aging is a disease that should be cured and offers a 'repair and maintenance approach to extending the functional life span of a human body.'⁶⁸ Suppose indefinite life extension technology exists, should a Christian pursue it? Is this technology a 'true miracle'?

The main issue with Gray's proposal is not the technology used to treat the physiological mechanisms that cause aging, but rather the premise that aging is a disease that should be cured.⁶⁹ This idea is wrong-headed. For Bulgakov, aging is not a consequence of the original sin; it is not an intrinsic evil or associated with the evil of the original sin. Jesus, who is the new Adam and experiences human nature without the consequences of the original sin (i.e., natural death and infirmity of the body) ages.⁷⁰ Bulgakov argues that if Jesus did not die a violent unnatural death, he would be a healthy and nonmortal man: 'Christ, like Adam before the Fall, was not subject to death . . . his body was without sickness.'⁷¹ Because Jesus ages, aging has an inherent value.⁷² Aging is endemic to the

68 Joel Garreau, 'The invincible Man; Aubrey de Grey, 44 Going on 1,000,' *The Washington Post* (31 October 2007).

69 Grey is co-founder of the Methuselah Foundation which is an organization committed to funding projects and research that will accelerate breakthroughs in longevity research. (For more information on this foundation see <https://www.mfoundation.org/>.) Methuselah is an Old Testament patriarch that lived to the age of 969 years.

70 Like Adam and Eve before the original sin, Jesus was immortal. Adam and Eve would not have died a natural death (e.g., death from old age or sickness). This does not mean that they were invincible. Even though Jesus was naturally immortal he was murdered on the cross. Sergius Bulgakov, *The Burning Bush: On the Orthodox Veneration of the Mother of God*, trans. Allan Smith (Grand Rapids, MI: William B. Eerdmans, 2009), 72.

71 Bulgakov, *The Lamb of God*, 7314. According to Bulgakov, Jesus was 'nonmortal' as opposed to immortal. Immortality, for Bulgakov, means liberation from the power of death. In other words, an immortal person cannot die by natural or unnatural causes. A nonmortal person cannot die from natural causes (e.g., old age, illness, disease). If Jesus did not die a violent death, he would have continued to age indefinitely. Bulgakov's rationale for his odd idea is that Jesus was not affected by the consequences of the original sin that included the experience of natural death.

72 What precisely is the theological value in aging requires another article and is beyond the scope of this article.

human experience. God intended prelapsarian humankind to age. The biblical authors consistently refer to the value of aging: 'The glory of young men is their strength, but the splendor of old men is their grey hair' (Prov 20:29).⁷³ Aging within the Judeo-Christian tradition is a venerable experience; it is a season in life between birth and death. However, this in no way should devalue the experience of aging, particularly as the human body begins to break down and the loss of autonomy occurs. Bulgakov is an idealist and his thought on aging may lead to an overly romantic interpretation of aging, but his underlying idea is that there is true value in aging and the result of aging, death.

On this point, Bulgakov is in good company with contemporary philosophers such as Jürgen Habermas, Paul Ricoeur, Alasdair MacIntyre, Susan Okin, Robert Goodin, and Leon Kass, who all argue that human weakness and frailty play an essential role in what it means to be human. For example, Kass argues that the natural cycle of birth, life, and death is a blessing and rejects enhancement technology that may seek to upend this norm.⁷⁴ Indefinitely extending life raises a host of societal and environmental issues from what to do with the elderly, and the effects of immortal persons on the economy, as well as the effect long-living people will have on limited natural resources. Kass notes that even if we grant that society will adapt to these issues, we have to seriously consider that the dying experience which is one of the most profound human experiences will be diminished. Hospice scholars such as Ira Byock and Chris Kerr, who are leaders in reframing the dying experience as a meaningful human experience, argue that the dying experience is one the most important experiences because it can result in wisdom and recognition of love and gratitude for the dying for their loved ones and the loved ones for the dying.⁷⁵ When the pain associated with the dying process is controlled, dying becomes a powerful experience that reorients one's entire life and provides for many the most meaningful opportunity that concludes life. Dying is a state in human life that is as valuable as birth, adolescence, or adulthood. Krass warns that without serious consideration of mortality and death, which is associated with the reality of death and dying experience, life will lose meaning.⁷⁶ Bulgakov would most likely rephrase Krass's statement as the dying experience provides meaning to life. In Bulgakov's *Sophiology of Death* which recounts his near-death experiences and his theology of Christ's death, provides a vivid argument that dying and death are meaningful human experiences that bring human beings closer to Jesus Christ. Christ's death transforms the dying experience from a punishment to a sacrosanct experience whereby the Christian, at least in prolonged natural dying, is prepared to love God and neighbor and the glory in the afterlife. The problem with Gray and many other researchers pursuing life extension research is that they unwittingly import the 'prejudices of present-day medical training have caused an inability to see dying as anything but a failure.'⁷⁷ Within this medical framework, death is

73 Here is a list of biblical verses that describe old age as a venerable experience: Job 12:12; Job 32:7; 1 Kings 12:6; Psalm 71:18; Psalm 92: 12–14; Isaiah 46:4.

74 Cf. Leon R. Krass, 'The Case for Mortality,' *The American Scholar* 52, no. 2 (Spring 1983): 173–91.

75 See Ira Byock's book *Dying Well*. Within the Hospice community, this text is a standard introduction to Hospice philosophy.

76 Krass, 183.

77 Christopher Kerr, *Death is but a Dream: Finding Hope and Meaning at Life's End*, Avery, 2020, 7.

meaningless and a defeat for life. For the Christian, however, the failure associated with death was overcome and redeemed by Jesus Christ. Bulgakov argues that Christ ‘partakes of the cup of death together with every dying person,’ and in so doing reveals God’s love in an intimate, ineffable manner.⁷⁸

Bulgakov adds to this discussion that to fear death and attempt to overcome or indefinitely postpone death, is not consistent with the Christian tradition. Moreover, referring to aging as a disease ignores Jesus’ aging and the biblical tradition of aging.

Gray commits the same error as Fedorov; he views death as an existential threat that human technology will overcome. For the Christian tradition, death is not the end, but rather the beginning. Death, and therefore aging process that results in death, are necessary. Bulgakov, in fact, in his later writings insists that after Jesus’ resurrection, death appropriates a new meaning as a pedagogical opportunity to prepare the human spirit for the general resurrection.⁷⁹ Death severs the spirit from the body to exist as a ‘spiritual-psychic being.’ Existence as a spiritual-psychic being is a foretaste of the general resurrection when the spiritual-psychic being will exist as a spiritual body. According to Bulgakov, in heaven, the spiritual-psychic being matures in its understanding and relationship to God and creation, and it is prepared for the general resurrection. Technologies that attempt to stop or revert the aging process to indefinitely postpone natural death are not consistent with a Christian understanding of death and the afterlife.

While these specific transhuman cyborg enhancements are not acceptable, moderate and radical cyborg enhancements are thornier issues because unlike transhumanist enhancements the spirit and consciousness remain in the enhanced body, and these enhancements do not necessarily imply a ‘false miracle.’

Moderate and Radical Cybernetic Enhancements

Therapeutic Cybernetic Enhancements

At the beginning of this article, I introduced Neuralink’s BMI technology that may ‘cure’ paralysis. Using Bulgakov’s terminology, this cognitive enhancement is a ‘true miracle’ because it is a work of love and mercy to return capacities that help overcome paralysis. This enhancement is consistent with the technologies and medications used by 20th-century physicians to cure ailments (i.e., perform miracles). Although the doctor/scientist may not make an explicit reference to God, he or she is open to God’s will in as much as it is a loving and merciful action. The technology itself, intention, and purpose comport with the Christian teaching that stresses loving your neighbor as you love yourself. Moderate enhancements that allow a paralyzed person to walk are an act of mercy, consistent with Jesus’ healings of a paralyzed man (see Mark 2:1–12). The invasive surgery that installs the microchip in the brain is consistent with Christian teachings because the purpose of the technology is to heal or at least improve the patient’s well-being. It may enhance the spirituality of the patient in so far as they can communicate and more fully

78 Sergius Bulgakov, *The Sophiology of Death: Essays on Eschatology: Personal, Political, Universal*, trans. Robert J. De La Noval, Eugene, OR: Cascade, 2021, 132.

79 Bulgakov, *The Bride of the Lamb*, 358.

participate in liturgical events. Not only is the technology appropriate but it is a proper use of human creative powers. Bulgakov believed that the use of human creative powers or what he also called ‘economic consumption’—by this, he meant human activity that ranged from eating to creative science—was a foretaste of the general resurrection and theosis of creation.⁸⁰ He wrote, in human consumption ‘the boundary between the living and the dead, the animate and the inanimate, is lifted. In it, nature receives assurance of the possibility of universal reanimation.’⁸¹ As Laura Hartman keenly noted for Bulgakov ‘insofar as consuming something makes it become a part of the consumer, and the consumer is closer to God than the consumed, then consumption can contribute to the process of theosis.’⁸² What Bulgakov is getting at here harks back to his idea that the human being is the hypostasis of creaturely Sophia. Consuming or in our context using technology to enhance a human function for a therapeutic purpose is an incipient beginning of the theosis of creation or the human sophianizing of creation. Because humankind is the hypostasis of creaturely Sophia, any creative activity that is done in accord with the love of God or minimally to allow life to thrive, is justified.⁸³ Therapeutic cyborg enhancements can be a foretaste of the theosis of creation, or a true miracle, which humankind through their relationship with Jesus Christ will take part in. The takeaway is that moderate therapeutic enhancements pose a little dilemma from a sophiological perspective.

The example I provide is straightforward. How is Bulgakov’s sophiology applicable to more controversial moderate therapeutic enhancements, such as cochlear implants?

Cochlear implants (CIs) improve hearing in deaf persons. CIs bypass the ‘damaged portions of the ear to deliver sound signals to the hearing (auditory) nerve . . . The signals stimulate the auditory nerve, which then directs the signals to the brain.’⁸⁴ After months of training, patients using this technology are reported to make considerable improvements in understanding speech. The implants do not cure deafness but rather enhance and augment hearing within deaf persons. For my purpose, CIs are moderate therapeutic enhancements. However, within the deaf community, the reception of CIs is mixed. While some view this technology as a ‘miracle,’ for many persons within the deaf

80 Bulgakov clearly had in his mind Paul’s epistle to the Romans, ‘The creation waits in eager expectation for the sons of God to be revealed’ (Rom 8: 19). The revelation of the sons of God maybe the revelation of the human race as the hypostasis of creaturely Sophia (creation).

81 Sergei Bulgakov, *The Philosophy of Economy: The World as Household*, trans. Catherine Evtuhov, Yale, CT: Yale University Press, 2014, 106.

82 Laura M. Hartman, ‘To Envision the Future’ in *The Christian Consumer: Living Faithfully in a Fragile World*, 128–68 (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2011), 157.

83 In his *The Philosophy of Economy*, Bulgakov argues that you do not need faith in Christ to realize that there exists an inner life force of the cosmos (by which he means created reality). The fact that life persists despite major catastrophes and drives the evolutionary process from simple to complex life forms is evidence that there is a life force in creation. This life force is creaturely Sophia.

84 Mayo Clinic Staff, ‘Cochlear Implants’, <https://www.mayoclinic.org/tests-procedures/cochlear-implants/about/pac-20385021>.

community, CIs perpetuate the idea that ‘deaf people need to be fixed.’⁸⁵ For deaf rights activists, CIs are an attempt to snuff out deaf culture and language (American Sign Language). Amelia Copper writes that ‘[m]any Deaf culturalists are deeply offended by what they perceive to be the inherently negative implication of cochlear implants: deafness is a medical disability that should be cured rather than a cultural identity that should be celebrated and respected.’⁸⁶

How might Bulgakov’s sophiology help to assess whether CIs should be pursued? I think Bulgakov’s sophiology, particularly his stress on the human body as in-flux, evolving and destined for resurrection and to become a ‘spiritual body’ helps to put the ethics of CIs into a Christian perspective. CIs are a therapeutic enhancement that comports with a Christian understanding of healing and miracle (e.g., restoring a lost or diminished capacity); however, there is no *mandate* to perform miracles. For the Christian, what is most important is the preparation for the general resurrection. Being deaf or having your hearing restored is not necessarily conducive to this event. Like most cyborg enhancements, CIs are ethically indifferent. What matters for moral evaluation is the intention and purpose behind the use of the technology. If a hearing-impaired person wants a CI because they want to be able to hear better, then they should pursue it. But it is by no means required. Moreover, deafness is not an evil that needs to be cured. Sophiology provides a sober realization that medical technology may assist humankind to better comport to the will of God, but ‘eye hath not seen, nor ear hath heard . . . the things which God hath prepared for them that love him’ (1 Cor 2:9). Healing a ‘disability’ is never an end-in-itself. Moreover, because we all share the same human nature, enhancements do not increase one’s dignity or self-worth.⁸⁷ The main takeaway a sophiological ethic provides is a means to assert that enhancements are never necessary. When enhancements threaten a culture that inadvertently undermines the dignity of a community of persons, we should carefully consider if the intention and purpose comport with the love of God and neighbor.

By the same token, radical therapeutic enhancements are ethical. Suppose climate change produces inhospitable conditions on Earth that require human beings to colonize other planets. Terraforming a new planet to make that planet hospitable for humanity’s survival may not be possible within the lifetime of human beings in need of a new home. Rather than terraforming a planet, a more immediate solution is to adapt humans to the environment of a new planet. A radical enhancement that replaced the respiratory system with a machine that will allow humans to breathe in another planetary atmosphere is justified. Replacing the respiratory system radically changes the human body; the respiratory system includes the airways to your lungs, the lungs, the bloodstream, the blood

85 Caroline Praderio, ‘Why Some People turned down a “medical miracle” and decided to stay deaf’, 3 January 2017, <https://www.insider.com/why-deaf-people-turn-down-cochlear-implants-2016-12>.

86 Amelia Cooper, ‘Hear Me Out,’ *Mo Medicine*, 116, no. 6, (2019): 469–71, 470.

87 I agree with Katherine Mascia’s assessment of cochlear implants that so long as the choices are informed, and it is an autonomous decision that helps achieve life goals, it is ethical. See Katherine Mascia, John Mascia, *The Bioethics of Providing Cochlear Implants to Children: Informed Choices and Autonomous Decision-Making*, *JADARA* 45, no. 2, (November 2019): 1–14, <https://nsuworks.nova.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1295&context=jadara>.

vessels, and many other components. For the sake of argument, assume that this technology would replace 60 percent of the human body with a machine. Even though the human person is now mostly a machine, it does not change what fundamentally makes us human. The human image and hypostasis remain, and this image and hypostasis will be resurrected and energized at the general resurrection. The technology itself is ethical. A mechanical respiratory system, even though it radically changes the natural body, is a 'true miracle'; the intention behind the technology is to save human lives, and the purpose of the technology is to breathe on a planet with an atmosphere that is different from Earth's atmosphere, thus this technology is justified.⁸⁸

The Body and Non-Therapeutic Cybernetic Enhancements

This thought experiment raises two important questions that Bulgakov's sophiology helps us address: (1) How much of the human body can we enhance with machinery before the human is no longer human? (2) Are non-therapeutic moderate and radical cyborg enhancements ethical?

Recall from our discussion of Bulgakov's theology of the spiritual body, that what is most important for the general resurrection is the presence of the hypostatic spirit, not necessarily the natural body. Again, most human beings' natural bodies will not exist at the general resurrection due to decomposition. At the resurrection event, the human proto-image in God's divine Sophia, or what St Paul refers to as the 'spiritual body' is realized for every human being. The spiritual body is the endpoint of this evolutionary process that God set into motion when God created creation. The spiritual body is a physical, material body that is spiritually enhanced. Our humanity does not rest in a body part or percentage of the 'natural body' but rather in the spirit's connection to the body. So long as that connection remains between body and spirit, the person is alive during and after the enhancement procedure, and the cyborg in question is a human being. Thus, radical enhancements do not *necessarily* take away our humanness or humanity. In the

88 The reader should note that although the distinction between therapeutic and non-therapeutic enhancements is a traditional framework for accessing the ethics of treatments, it is limited in application. For instance, suppose there are two children who are both in the bottom five-percentile for height. However, one child's shortness is a result of low growth hormone levels while the other child is healthy but genetically predisposed to shortness. Both children will face societal challenges due to their lack of height. While prescribing somatropin to the first child is a therapeutic treatment (i.e., it corrects the lack of naturally occurring growth hormone), prescribing somatropin to the second child is a non-therapeutic treatment, it is an enhancement. In this situation, the distinction between therapeutic and non-therapeutic prescriptions of somatropin is not helpful. Nevertheless, the distinction between therapeutic and non-therapeutic treatments in application to bioethical discussions is ubiquitous within Catholic moral theological discourses. For example, William May, who was a leading Catholic Moral theologian and author of *Catholic Bioethics and the Gift of Human Life*, uses the framework of therapeutic and non-therapeutic treatments to elucidate magisterial teaching on bioethics. See William E. May, *Catholic Bioethics and the Gift of Human Life*, third edition, Huntington, IN: Our Sunday Visitor, 2013.

case above, a radically enhanced respiratory system is a true miracle because it saves human lives, and thus it is consistent with Jesus' healing mission.

Bulgakov's response to Fedorov also provides a boundary for cyborg technologies. Technologies that disregard or kill the body and upload consciousness or copy neural networks to a hard drive are inappropriate. Whenever the link between the spirit and body is broken, human consciousness is no longer present. In Bulgakov's sophiology, the human spirit is human consciousness that functions in concert with the organism of the brain. Simply copying the neural network of the brain to a hard drive would not necessarily transfer consciousness. At best copying of neural networks would result in a kind-of zombie-like human that is a mere shadow of the human being before he or she died. Cybernetic enhancements are ethical when they enhance a living person and do not break the connection between the body and spirit. The upshot is that some elements of the 'natural body' must remain. The neurological criteria (i.e., brain death criteria) that are the standard criteria used by medical professionals in US hospitals to determine death provide some clarity here. According to these criteria, death occurs when there is a complete and irreversible cessation of the brainstem reflexes and cerebral responsiveness, absence of respiration, and etiology and irreversibility of coma.⁸⁹ As soon as brain death occurs, the link is severed between the spirit and the body. When a death occurs, what makes you fully human (body and spirit) do not exist. You are no longer a human, but rather a disembodied human spirit. Thus, cybernetic enhancements themselves are ethically indifferent so long as they do not necessitate brain death.

Are non-therapeutic moderate or radical enhancements ethical? If we return to Bulgakov's insight on the spiritual body, non-therapeutic enhancements in themselves are not unethical because the body is open to enhancement. However, to determine if a non-therapeutic enhancement is ethical, we must consider whether the intention and purpose comport with the Christian tradition. Cyborg enhancements that proceed from a self-serving intention are not appropriate because egoism is a selfish intention; they are false miracles. Moderate or radical cyborg enhancements for athletic purposes (i.e., to run the fastest or lift the most weight overhead) are false miracles. Nevertheless, there are limits to applying Bulgakov's thoughts to this discussion. For example, in real-world applications determining intentionality is difficult, and in many situations, that actor may have multiple intentions. Bulgakov is not an ethicist and does not provide insight on how to navigate more complex situations such as a person who had a cyborg enhancement for a therapeutic purpose but uses that enhancement for non-therapeutic purposes. Nevertheless, Bulgakov provides a unique sophiological perspective that defends therapeutic moderate and radical cyborg enhancements and provides clarity on the limits of cyborg enhancement technology, while rejecting certain transhuman cyborg enhancements as inconsistent with the Christian tradition.

89 See The Department of Health, 'New York State Guidelines for Determining Brain Death' https://www.health.ny.gov/professionals/hospital_administrator/letters/2011/brain_death_guidelines.htm.

Conclusion

Sergius Bulgakov's sophiology in no way exhausts the debate over what cybernetic enhancements are ethical. However, his thought is relevant to the looming ethical issue of whether cybernetic enhancements are ethical. Bulgakov provides a nuanced Eastern Christian approach that has been underrepresented in cybernetic discussions.

Bulgakov's sophiology of miracles offers both a defense of cybernetic modifications and some criteria for their limits. Based on his thought, I argued that the human body is not simply open to enhancement but is made for enhancement. When the cybernetic enhancements are for therapeutic purposes or the intention and purpose of those enhancements comport to the Christian tradition even if they raise our capacities beyond those ever possessed by any human being, they are miraculous and ethical. In some sense, these enhancements, because they are in accord with God's will for survival and healing, are a foretaste of the capacities that our bodies will have at the general resurrection. The spiritual body humankind receives at the general resurrection is the ultimate human body enhancement. Bulgakov's work on the spiritual body reveals that what is resurrected is not necessarily the human body, as most human beings will not have a corpse, but rather the 'bodily entelechy' in the creaturely Sophia. Therefore, cybernetic enhancements that do not break the spirit-body entelechy connection do not undermine the integrity of the human body. So long as cybernetic enhancements proceed from a therapeutic intention and purpose, they are ethical. Within Bulgakov's schema, cybernetic moderate or radical therapeutic enhancements are 'true miracles,' acts of love and mercy that work in synergy with God's will for humankind.

Nevertheless, there are limits to the use of cyborg enhancement technologies. Cybernetic enhancements that devalue the human body or have a selfish intention or purpose are not ethical. However, non-therapeutic cybernetic enhancements are thornier issues. Given the fact that the body is open to enhancement, moderate and radical non-therapeutic cyborg enhancements in-themselves are not the object of the ethical dilemma, but rather the rationale for the enhancement is important for ethical deliberation.

Based on Bulgakov's thought there are definitive limits to cybernetic enhancements. Transhuman cyborg enhancements are unethical when they depend 'upon an ontology of information' that subsumes consciousness to a neural network or attempt to achieve immortality. This is a 'false miracle' or a misuse of the human being's sophianic potential to be the hypostasis of the creaturely Sophia. Moreover, any enhancement that results in the total loss of the body or brain death (e.g., uploading consciousness to a database and destroying the body) is unethical. This article has only outlined Bulgakov's sophiology and how that sophiology may be relevant to the cybernetic discussion. More research is needed on the application of his thought to this looming ethical issue, particularly on the effects of this technology on the environment and animals from a sophiological point of view.

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